Of course, Owlie didn't know what to do with it. She was just a baby, after all. If the mother owl had been there, she would have softened the meat and shoved it down Owlie's throat. Payal's mother decided she had to be mother owl! She picked up a tiny bit of meat with her right hand and squished it up until it was soft. Then with her left hand, she pressed open Owlie's beak and shoved the food down. In a second, Owlie fell off her perch on to the floor of the cage. She lay on her back on the floor of the cage with feet up in the air.

'Mom!' Payal cried, 'You've killed her!' Payal's mother was equally aghast. 'Oh!' she said. 'Oh, what have I done ? The poor, little bird!' After Payal and her mother had finished crying and hugging each other, they started talking bravely about where to bury Owlie. Just then, Owlie opened one eye and then the other. She got onto her feet and quietly climbed the perch!



Payal learnt later that falling on her back and pretending to be dead was Owlie's way of defending herself against danger. Not that Payal's mother was a danger to Owlie, but the baby owl did not know that then. So that was Owlie's first day at home.

In the beginning, Owlie had to be forced to eat. That was Mom's job. But Owlie soon realised that if a hand came towards her it meant food! Her mouth would open automatically and her beak would snap around what was offered. Only, Owlie found it difficult to know when she was being offered food, and would try to take a bit out of any hand that came her way. This meant lots of bitten fingers for Payal and her mother.

Reading up more about owls and their habits, Payal discovered that Owlie was a Spotted Owlet. She had the typical grey-brown coat, heavily spotted with white, the pale face, yellow eyes and the white neckband, which looked like a ribbon, Payal decided. Soon, Payal took over the job of looking after Owlie. She saw that the cage was cleaned every day. She filled the water bowl. Once Owlie began to eat by herself, Payal too could feed her. She loved the way Owlie took a piece of raw meat from her hand. During the day, Payal kept the cage covered. Owls are night birds, so they slept during the day. At night, when owls are active, Payal took off the cover. They had decided that they would let Owlie fly away once she had grown bigger. But that meant that she had to learn to fly. To do that, Owlie had to be in a closed room.

After much discussion, Owlie's cage was shifted to the library. It was a lovely room with two doors – one which led to the rest of the house and the other that opened into the garden. It was also Payal's favourite room. It had tall bookshelves and she spent hours